

# Self-Regulated Learning Guide

Odisee Brussels · Student Success Project 2025–2026

*Tool 3 of 3 · Part of the Bridging the Gap Project · Built on EEF Teaching and Learning Toolkit (2025)*

This is the complete Self-Regulated Learning Guidance Book for Odisee Brussels — combining the original SRL Guide with the full implementation workflow, EEF recommendations, SWOT analysis, SMART criteria, practical student tools, and international evidence from nearby universities. Everything a student, lecturer, mentor, or coordinator needs is in this single document.

|                                                                                                             |                                                                                                         |                                                                                    |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>+7 to +8 months</b><br>extra learning progress<br><i>EEF Toolkit, 2025 — highest-impact, lowest-cost</i> | <b><math>r = .71</math></b><br>correlation<br><i>SRL ↔ academic adjustment (Van Rooij et al., 2018)</i> | <b>3 habits</b><br>Plan · Monitor · Evaluate<br><i>EEF Recommendation 2 (2025)</i> |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

## 1. What Is Self-Regulated Learning?

Self-regulated learning (SRL) is the ability to take ownership of your own studying. It means setting a goal before you begin, checking your understanding while you work, and reflecting honestly on what helped and what did not after you finish.

The Education Endowment Foundation defines it as: students' ability to monitor, direct and review their own learning — usually by setting goals, and monitoring and evaluating their own academic progress (EEF, 2025). Research confirms that self-regulated learners apply these strategies consistently, and that this promotes genuine learner independence.

## 2. Why Does This Matter at Odisee Brussels?

Odisee University of Applied Sciences aims to provide opportunities for a wide range of learners and to reduce unnecessary dropout by removing barriers related to access, services, and institutional support (Odisee, n.d.-b). The Brussels campus presents a particular challenge: institutional data confirm that students with a migrant background show significantly lower study efficiency at Brussels compared to all other campuses.

Research shows that many of these students arrive without the structured study habits that university requires — not because of a lack of ability or motivation, but because effective study strategies are rarely taught explicitly before university entry (Van Rooij et al., 2018; Fokkens-Bruinsma et al., 2021). Almarzouki (2024) found that prolonged stress from financial insecurity and language difficulty directly impairs working memory — SRL skills help students recover and refocus even under pressure.

Van Rooij et al. (2018) demonstrated a correlation of .71 between self-regulated study behaviour and academic adjustment in first-year students — the strongest predictor in their entire model, above motivation and above prior grades. Koh et al. (2022) followed 3,316 first-generation students and found that self-regulation was the bridge between believing you can succeed and actually staying enrolled into second year. The EEF (2025) estimates this approach adds +7 to +8 months of extra learning progress for

disadvantaged students at very low cost. Dignath and Veenman (2021) confirmed teachers can build SRL into existing lessons simply by asking students to plan before and reflect after — no workshops needed.

### 3. The Three Steps — Plan · Monitor · Evaluate

Three steps. Six minutes total per session. Built into what already happens — no extra sessions, no extra budget, no extra workload.

| Step              | When                      | What You Do                                                                                                                                                                                                          | The Evidence                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-------------------|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>1 PLAN</b>     | Before every session      | What is my specific goal for this session?<br><br>How will I approach this — reading, practising, writing, or discussing?<br><br>How much time do I have and what can I realistically achieve?                       | Fokkens-Bruinsma et al. (2021): time management and goal-setting are the two strongest predictors of first-year academic success. EEF Rec. 2: activating prior knowledge before a task significantly improves learning outcomes.                                              |
| <b>2 MONITOR</b>  | During — every 20 minutes | Am I genuinely understanding this, or just moving through the material?<br><br>Am I still working towards the goal I set at the start?<br><br>Is my current approach working — or should I try a different strategy? | Van Rooij et al. (2018): correlation of .71 between self-regulated study behaviour and academic adjustment in first-year students — the single strongest predictor, above motivation and prior grades. EEF Rec. 3: modelling metacognitive thinking out loud during sessions. |
| <b>3 EVALUATE</b> | After every session       | What went well in this session? Name it specifically so it can be repeated.<br><br>What was difficult or unclear? Name it honestly so it can be addressed.<br><br>What is one thing I will do differently next time? | Jansen et al. (2019): meta-analysis of 126 higher education studies — teaching reflection after completing work consistently improves both grades and study habits. EEF Rec. 2: evaluating and monitoring own learning is a core metacognitive strategy.                      |

### 4. EEF Recommendations — How They Are Applied

This guide is built directly on the seven EEF Recommendations for Metacognition and Self-Regulated Learning (2025). The table below shows how each recommendation is applied in practice at Odisee Brussels.

| EEF Recommendation (2025)                                         | How It Is Applied in This Guide                                                                      |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Rec. 1: Teachers acquire professional understanding of SRL</b> | Teaching staff briefed in induction week on all three steps. This guide is their reference document. |

| EEF Recommendation (2025)                                              | How It Is Applied in This Guide                                                                                                                                    |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Rec. 2: Explicitly teach students to plan, monitor and evaluate</b> | Students receive this guide in Week 1. All three steps are introduced and briefly practised in a teaching session.                                                 |
| <b>Rec. 3: Model metacognitive thinking out loud</b>                   | Lecturers verbalise their own thinking during sessions — pausing to check understanding, adjusting approach — showing what self-regulation looks like in practice. |
| <b>Rec. 4: Set appropriate challenge and support</b>                   | Peer mentor adjusts support level to each student's stage of habit formation. Coordinator provides proactive support at five-weekly check-ins.                     |
| <b>Rec. 6: Teach students to manage their own learning</b>             | Tools A, B and C give students practical independence without requiring ongoing instruction from staff.                                                            |
| <b>Rec. 7: Sustain and develop practice across the institution</b>     | Year-end reflection session. Outcomes feed into next year's intake planning. Embedded in both teaching and mentoring — not a one-off event.                        |

## 5. The Three Student Tools

These three tools take five minutes total. They are for students' own use — not assessed, not submitted, not checked. They are habits students build for themselves.

### Tool A — 2-Minute Planner (use BEFORE every session)

| Question                                              | Your answer — write it here |
|-------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| What is my goal for this session?                     |                             |
| How will I study? (read / practise / write / discuss) |                             |
| How long do I have?                                   |                             |

### Tool B — 20-Minute Monitor Pause (use DURING every session)

Stop every 20 minutes and ask one question:

*Am I genuinely understanding this — or am I just moving through the words?*

If the answer is the second one, go back to the point where you last understood. Find the gap. That moment is where learning actually happens. EEF Recommendation 2 (2025) confirms that monitoring and adjusting during a task is the key metacognitive strategy that improves outcomes.

### Tool C — 3-Minute Reflection (use AFTER every session)

| Question                        | Your answer — write it here |
|---------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| What went well in this session? |                             |
| What was difficult or unclear?  |                             |

| Question                              | Your answer — write it here |
|---------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| What will I do differently next time? |                             |

## 6. Implementation Workflow — Who Does What and When

SRL is not taught in a separate workshop. It is woven into what already happens — every teaching session, every mentoring meeting, every coordinator check-in. This is how the EEF recommends it (2025): embedded in the curriculum, not added on top of it.

| When                           | Where                | What Happens                                                                                                                                   | EEF Recommendation                                        |
|--------------------------------|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Induction Week</b>          | Teaching session     | Students receive this guide. The three steps are introduced and briefly practised together.                                                    | Rec. 1: Build professional understanding of SRL           |
| <b>Every Teaching Session</b>  | Classroom            | Lecturer asks one opening question (Plan) and one closing question (Evaluate). Thinks out loud during the session — modelling self-regulation. | Rec. 2 & 3: Teach and model plan, monitor, evaluate       |
| <b>Every Mentoring Session</b> | On campus or online  | Mentor opens with goal-setting (Plan). Mentor closes with a reflection question (Evaluate).                                                    | Rec. 6: Teach students to manage learning independently   |
| <b>Every 5 Weeks</b>           | Coordinator check-in | Mentor flags if SRL habits are not forming. Coordinator offers proactive, warm support.                                                        | Rec. 4: Set appropriate challenge and support             |
| <b>End of Year</b>             | Reflection session   | Students reflect on how their study habits changed across 21 weeks. Anonymised reflections inform next year's intake support.                  | Rec. 7: Sustain and embed practice across the institution |

## 7. International Evidence — What Works and Where

Self-regulated learning has been successfully implemented at universities across Europe and beyond. The examples below are the most directly comparable to Odisee Brussels.

| University / Study                                                                | What They Did & Results                                                                                                                        | What Odisee Can Take                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Baars et al. (2015 &amp; 2024) University of Applied Sciences, Netherlands</b> | 315 first-year students. SRL and executive function together explained 39.8% of variance in credits obtained in Year 1. Students with stronger | Directly comparable to Odisee Brussels — a university of applied sciences in the Netherlands. Proved that teaching SRL to first-year students measurably increases credits passed. This is the exact outcome Odisee needs. |

| University / Study                                                           | What They Did & Results                                                                                                                                                                             | What Odisee Can Take                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                              | self-monitoring earned significantly more credits.                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>Erasmus University Rotterdam 'Ace Your Self-Study' App — Netherlands</b>  | Mobile app built on the Plan · Monitor · Evaluate framework for first-year psychology students. Results: significant increases in autonomous motivation and metacognition.                          | Same three-step framework as this guide. Erasmus proved it works at university level in the Dutch higher education context — same system, same culture, directly comparable to Brussels.                                      |
| <b>Dignath &amp; Veenman (2021) Classroom observation studies — Europe</b>   | Systematic review of European classroom studies. Two teacher questions per session — one at start (plan) and one at end (reflect) — were sufficient to build SRL habits. No extra workshops needed. | Odisee lecturers need only two questions per session. That is the entire workload change. Dignath & Veenman proved this across multiple European classrooms.                                                                  |
| <b>Simón-Grábalos et al. (2025) Spanish Universities — systematic review</b> | SRL embedded in normal teaching by lecturers achieved a 71% success rate. Standalone workshops were significantly less effective.                                                                   | Embedding works. Workshops do not. This guide is embedded by design — into teaching and mentoring — following exactly what works.                                                                                             |
| <b>Koh et al. (2022) 3,316 First-Generation Students — International</b>     | Self-regulation was the bridge between believing you can succeed and actually staying enrolled into second year. Strongest predictor of retention after controlling for academic self-efficacy.     | For first-generation students specifically — the majority of the Odisee Brussels target group — SRL is not optional. It is what converts confidence into persistence and persistence into completion.                         |
| <b>EEF Teaching and Learning Toolkit (2025) 30+ country evidence base</b>    | Metacognition and self-regulation: +7 to +8 months of additional learning progress for disadvantaged students. Highest-impact, lowest-cost strategy in the Toolkit.                                 | The anchor for every conversation about SRL at Odisee. When any stakeholder asks 'does this work?' — the answer is +7 to +8 months, at zero extra cost, grounded in the largest evidence base in European education research. |

## 8. SWOT Analysis

An honest assessment of the strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats for implementing this guide at Odisee Brussels.

| Strengths                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | Opportunities                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p>Evidence-based — grounded in EEF (+7 to +8 months proven impact)</p> <p>No extra sessions or budget required</p> <p>Fits into existing teaching and mentoring without adding workload</p> <p>Directly addresses the study efficiency gap at Brussels campus</p> | <p>Scalable across all Odisee Brussels programmes at zero extra cost</p> <p>Strengthens peer mentoring and early alert — all three tools reinforce each other</p> <p>Builds lifelong student independence beyond the first year</p> |

| Strengths                                                                                                                                                                                   | Opportunities                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Gives students autonomy and builds long-term academic confidence                                                                                                                            | Aligns directly with Odisee's inclusion vision and policy (n.d.-a, n.d.-b)                                                                                                                                          |
| Weaknesses                                                                                                                                                                                  | Threats                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| Habit formation takes time — not instant results<br>Requires consistent reinforcement from staff and mentors to embed<br>Students may initially resist or underestimate the reflection step | High student stress undermines self-regulation (Almarzouki, 2024)<br>Language barriers may affect the quality of written reflections<br>Without peer mentor or staff reinforcement, habits may not form and persist |

*The weaknesses and threats are not reasons to avoid the approach — they are areas where the implementation plan already has responses built in. Stress is addressed through peer mentoring (Tool 1). Language barriers are acknowledged by allowing reflection in any language. The risk of habits not forming is mitigated by systematic mentor check-ins and early alert follow-up (Tool 2).*

## 9. SMART Criteria

|          | Criterion         | How This Guide Meets It                                                                                                                                                           |
|----------|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>S</b> | <b>Specific</b>   | Three explicitly defined strategies — Plan, Monitor, Evaluate — with three practical student tools, embedded in teaching sessions and peer mentoring meetings at Odisee Brussels. |
| <b>M</b> | <b>Measurable</b> | Progress tracked through mentor check-in notes every five weeks; year-end student reflections; connection to Early Alert Protocol data (Tool 2).                                  |
| <b>A</b> | <b>Achievable</b> | No new sessions, no new budget, no extra staff. Two questions per teaching session. Embedded in what already happens. Zero extra workload for anyone.                             |
| <b>R</b> | <b>Relevant</b>   | Directly addresses the study efficiency gap for first-generation and migrant-background students at the Brussels campus, confirmed in institutional data.                         |
| <b>T</b> | <b>Time-Bound</b> | Introduced in induction week. Embedded across 21 weeks. Formally reviewed at end of year. Outcomes inform next year's intake support.                                             |

## 10. Full Evidence Base

| Source                                            | Contribution to This Guide                                                                                                                                                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>EEF Teaching &amp; Learning Toolkit (2025)</b> | Metacognition and self-regulation: +7 to +8 months additional learning progress. Highest-impact, lowest-cost strategy. Seven recommendations form the backbone of the implementation plan. |
| <b>Van Rooij et al. (2018)</b>                    | Correlation of .71 between self-regulated study behaviour and academic adjustment in first-year students — the strongest predictor in the model, above motivation and prior grades.        |

| Source                                                        | Contribution to This Guide                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|---------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Jansen et al. (2019)</b>                                   | Meta-analysis of 126 higher education studies: teaching SRL consistently improves both grades and study habits across all disciplines and student backgrounds.                                                                  |
| <b>Fokkens-Bruinsma et al. (2021)</b>                         | Time management and autonomous motivation are the two strongest predictors of first-year academic success. Both are directly developed through the Plan step.                                                                   |
| <b>Koh et al. (2022)</b>                                      | For 3,316 diverse first-generation students: self-regulation was the bridge between believing you can succeed and staying enrolled into second year.                                                                            |
| <b>Baars et al. (2015 &amp; 2024)</b>                         | At a University of Applied Sciences in the Netherlands: stronger self-monitoring and planning directly predicted more credits earned in first year. SRL and executive function together explained 39.8% of variance in credits. |
| <b>Dignath &amp; Veenman (2021)</b>                           | Two teacher questions per session — one at the start, one at the end — are sufficient to build SRL habits. No extra workshops or sessions needed.                                                                               |
| <b>Simón-Grábalos et al. (2025)</b>                           | SRL embedded in normal teaching by lecturers achieved a 71% success rate. Standalone workshops were significantly less effective.                                                                                               |
| <b>Almarzouki (2024)</b>                                      | Financial stress and language difficulty directly impair working memory. SRL habits help students recover and refocus — especially relevant for Brussels students managing multiple pressures.                                  |
| <b>Odisee University of Applied Sciences (n.d.-a, n.d.-b)</b> | Odisee aims to reduce unnecessary dropout and provide inclusive learning environments. This guide is a direct implementation of that institutional commitment.                                                                  |

### A note to teaching staff and programme coordinators

This guide is not a reflection on what has or has not been done before. It is a response to a well-documented challenge — the study efficiency gap for first-generation and migrant-background students at Odisee Brussels. The three steps in this guide are low-cost, evidence-based, and designed to complement what already happens in your sessions. Your role is not to add more to your workload, but to use two questions — one at the start, one at the end — to help students develop habits that will serve them throughout their degree.